The BJP Focuses on Farmers and Development More than Terrorism and Mandir

One of the big puzzles for those who oppose Narendra Modi and the BJP is why the party continued to grow in agrarian and rural India even in 2019. Despite tanking job-creation numbers, agrarian distress and declining growth numbers, it continued to attract voters beyond the core base. This continued to be the case until the Modi government passed three new agriculture laws in September 2020, which sought to reform Indian farming and introduce private procurement of farm produce.[12] These legislations led to massive protests by farmers, especially from Punjab and Haryana. Suspicious that they might in the future lose governmental Minimum Support Price (MSP) guarantees on their crops at state-run Agriculture Market Produce Committee (APMC) mandis, farmers' unions began a protest in Delhi, which was ongoing a year later at the time of writing. Prime Minister Modi assured the protestors that MSP would remain—that his government had significantly increased procurements under it[13]—and that the APMC mandis would not be done away with. Eventually, however, the government withdrew the three laws.[14] A detailed analysis of this unfolding saga and its impact on farmers is beyond this book's scope. While these laws and the protest movement could significantly change the nature of the BJP's engagement with farmers, this section looks at how the party retained farmer support until 2019.

The assumption so far has been that voters are turning rightwards because of the BJP's cultural nationalism and identity politics. Insights gleaned from the Narad Index show that the truth may be a bit more complicated. At a time when combative BJP ministers and spokespersons assume an increasingly aggressive take-no-prisoners approach on Hinduness and redefining nationalism, it is easy to miss the fact that, below the top layer of aggression, there are other layers in the party's political outreach. While the headlines tend to be dominated by the controversial identity-based stuff, below the radar, the BJP has been focusing a great deal on the messaging to farmers and on the narrative of development. One of the findings that greatly surprised us was that,